Epilogue

In late 2016, a few months after AlphaGo defeated Lee Sedol and as Facebook algorithms were stoking dangerous racist sentiments in Myanmar, I published *Homo Deus*. Though my academic training had been in medieval and early modern military history, and though I have no background in the technical aspects of computer science, I suddenly found myself, post-publication, with the reputation of an AI expert. This opened the doors to the offices of scientists, entrepreneurs and world leaders interested in AI and afforded me a fascinating, privileged look into the complex dynamics of the AI revolution.

It turned out that my previous experience researching topics such as English strategy in the Hundred Years War and studying paintings from the Thirty Years War[1] wasn't entirely unrelated to this new field. In fact, it gave me a rather unique historical perspective on the events unfolding rapidly in AI labs, corporate offices, military headquarters and presidential palaces. Over the past eight years I have had numerous public and private discussions about AI, particularly about the dangers it poses, and with each passing year the tone has become more urgent. Conversations that in 2016 felt like idle philosophical speculations about a distant future had, by 2024, acquired the focused intensity of a hospital A & E department.

I am neither a politician nor a businessperson and have little talent for what these vocations demand. But I do believe that an understanding of history can be useful in gaining a better grasp of present-day technological, economic and cultural developments – and, more urgently, in changing our political priorities. Politics is largely a matter of priorities. Should we cut the health-care budget and spend more on defence? Is our more pressing security threat terrorism or climate change? Do we focus on regaining a lost patch of ancestral territory or concentrate on creating a common economic zone with the neighbours? Priorities determine how citizens vote, what